

Manufacturing equipment customers are being challenged by the growing complexity of software used to control their machines. The need for better performance and efficiency and safer operation is driving this trend. Meeting these demands often means incorporating more software to control complex dynamics and provide better supervisory and fault detection logic

the enterprise as well as between partners. Success in India comes from offering solutions that are focused on solving real problems. The companies that are able to do this are doing well.

"Industrial automation market worldwide is being driven by several trends. In emerging nations like India, industrial and factory automation is rapidly advancing. More and more manufacturing is getting automated, and these emerging countries are skipping generations to go with the latest available technologies. Integration to enterprise systems, sustainability and eco-friendliness, and availability of smarter technologies like sensors, HMI and communication technologies are driving automation markets worldwide," says Choudhury.

"Local Indian players struggle in terms of economies of scale, which is a distinct advantage enjoyed by the global players who have huge R&D expenditure along with a strong sales and marketing presence in the Indian market. Frugal innovation to reduce the total cost of ownership significantly would definitely drive growth. Local players could also look for potential partnerships with the growing number of Indian design houses that are doing a lot of product development and designs for their global clients," he says.

"With the government's thrust towards boosting the electronics manufacturing industry and the solar

industry, manufacturing will pick up in both the sectors, leading to a rise in automated plants. As highlighted earlier, energy costs are driving efficiency on the motor controls side," Choudhury added.

Challenges to market growth

Increased productivity is one outcome of a series of benefits that automation brings to the shop floor. Most adopters recognise that there are internal barriers to cross and that's not easy. Hence automation must always be seen in the context of the bigger picture.

"Automation is not just the replacement of man by machine to do routine tasks. It is the standardisation of processes and methods that can be fed into machines unlike humans. Of course, not to forget machines that can be put to work in high-risk/hazardous areas that we will not risk with human resources," explain Wadhwa and Nandakumar.

"However, the biggest benefit is the possibility of training the very staff who were doing repetitive tasks in better, meaningful jobs, which gives them too a chance to rise up the social ladder. In other words, it is a holistic processing tool towards sustainability. When our industry awakens to such a vision, people will embrace automation for all such benefits, not merely by a return-on-investment (ROI) approach," they added.

Cost of automation is one big reason why small to mid-size Indian manufacturers have been slow to take up automation while trying to justify the ROI

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